

NotebookLM Case Study



Implementing a Google Workspace-native AI strategy for document intelligence at a hypothetical off-price retailer.

The Problem We're Solving

At All For Less, the answer exists — but finding it takes too long.



The New Team Member

Needs a quick answer but doesn't know which document, folder, or system houses it. Hunting through shared drives takes hours. Asking a colleague pulls someone away from their own work.

Example questions:

"Where is the return policy for vendor X?"

"What's the standard markdown approval process?"



The Experienced Associate

Knows the answer exists but can't recall the specific document — especially for infrequent, edge-case situations. The information is too specialized to keep top-of-mind across hundreds of SKUs, vendors, and policies.

Example questions:

"What were the freight terms on the Q2 closeout deal?"

"Which spec sheet covers the seasonal packaging requirements?"



The Manager or Buyer

Needs a rolled-up summary or overview across a large body of documents — not one specific answer, but a synthesized picture drawn from many sources at once.

Example questions:

"Summarize what buyers purchased in the last 12 months"

"Give me an overview of our open PRDs and product specs"

"What do our finance outputs say about Q3 margin trends?"

The cost is not just time — it's missed deals, delayed decisions, and knowledge locked inside documents no one can find fast enough.

Why Has This not Been a Problem Before

350+

Store Locations

Across 28 states

~40%

Below MSRP

Average savings vs. retail

Lean IT

Culture

Every dollar counts

All For Less is an off-price retailer competing on value. We compete by buying excess inventory, overruns, and closeouts from top brands and passing savings directly to customers. *The business model thrives on operational efficiency and low overhead.* Technology investments are evaluated strictly on ROI before any dollar is committed.

What Is Google NotebookLM?

A free AI research assistant from Google, powered by Gemini.
(Renamed Gemini Notebook in July 2026.)

1

Document Intelligence

Upload PDFs, reports, or other documents and ask questions in plain English. Instant answers from your own documents.

2

Audio Overviews

Turns uploaded content into a podcast-style audio summary — great for managers on the go.

3

Source-Grounded Answers

Every response is tied to your source documents only. No hallucinations from outside data.

NotebookLM graduated from Google Labs to a full Google product in 2024 and is one of the most genuinely useful free AI tools available.

**No IT infrastructure
Browser-based**

How Google Positions NotebookLM for Business

Source: Google Workspace & Google Labs Official Documentation



Finance & Strategy

Upload *financial reports, market analyses, and internal strategy docs*. Ask it to create executive summaries, extract metrics, and identify strategic implications.

At All For Less:

Buyer reports, margin analyses, seasonal trend docs, vendor financial summaries.



Onboarding & Training

Upload training *manuals, guides, policy docs, and FAQs*. New hires find answers buried in lengthy documents and get cited step-by-step responses.

At All For Less:

Store SOPs, HR policies, markdown procedures, new buyer orientation materials.



Sales Enablement

Upload *product specs and market research*. Ask it to create tailored meeting plans and answer product questions for more confident buyer conversations.

At All For Less:

Vendor agreements, product specs, closeout deal terms, PRDs for merchandise buyers.



Research & Analysis

Summarize key findings, identify trends, and compare approaches — all with per-sentence citations you can verify in one click.

At All For Less:

Competitor pricing research, trend reports, merchandise and category performance reviews.

Google Customer Proof: Rivian moves from technical docs to creative planning in minutes. Sonata Design reduced product inquiry time with a NotebookLM knowledge base.

NotebookLM Free vs. Enterprise — Data Privacy & Leakage Risk

FEATURE	FREE (Standard)  Data Leakage Risk	ENTERPRISE (Google Cloud)  Recommended for Sensitive Data
Cost	Free — Google account only	~\$9/license/mo via Google Cloud (15-license minimum). Also included in many Google Workspace plans.
Data Used for Training	 Data MAY be used to improve Google products. Uploaded vendor docs could inform Google's models.	 Data is NEVER used for model training. Contractual guarantee via Data Processing Agreement (DPA).
Data Leakage Risk	 HIGH risk for confidential docs. Vendor pricing, supplier terms, and trade data should NOT be uploaded.	 LOW risk. Enterprise data governance, strict access controls, and legal DPA protections in place.
Security Controls	 Standard Google account security only. No VPC, no audit logs, no admin visibility.	 VPC Service Controls, IAM role-based access, audit logging, and admin dashboards.
Compliance	 No formal compliance certifications. Not suitable for regulated data environments.	 Meets enterprise compliance standards. Data residency controls available.
Collaboration	Personal use only — no team sharing or admin controls.	Secure team sharing via IAM roles. IT can control who accesses which notebooks.
Notebooks / Limits	Standard caps on queries & notebooks.	5× higher usage capacity & larger upload limits.
File Types Supported	PDF, Google Docs, URLs, plain text.	Adds DOCX, PPTX, XLSX (full Microsoft Office support).
Support	Community support only. No SLA.	Google enterprise support with formal SLAs.

Action for All For Less: Use FREE for non-sensitive pilot documents only. Upload vendor pricing, supplier contracts, or trade data ONLY on Enterprise with DPA in place.

Why NotebookLM? Comparing Document AI Tools

	Google NotebookLM ★ Recommended	Claude Projects ChatGPT Agent	Glean Enterprise Search	Microsoft 365 Copilot (Copilot Notebooks)
Cost	Free / ~\$9/user/mo	\$20-30/user/mo each	~\$45-50+/user/mo \$50K min contract	\$30/user/mo (Enterprise) or \$18/user/mo (Business, <300 users). Needs M365 license.
Source Grounding	Strict RAG — ONLY your uploaded docs. Zero outside data.	Blends files + broad training knowledge. Harder to audit.	RAG across all connected apps. Respects access permissions.	Indexes SharePoint, Teams, OneDrive, Outlook. M365- scoped.
Citation Accuracy	Per-sentence citations. Every claim traceable.	May reference uploads without pinpointing location.	Grounded in indexed sources. Strong multi-tool attribution.	Cites SharePoint documents. Strong within M365 ecosystem.
Data Privacy & Leakage	FREE ⚠️: may train Google models. ENTERPRISE ✅: DPA + no training.	Business plans: no training, DPA available. Consumer plans vary.	✅ No storage, no training. Data removed post-query. DPA available.	✅ Enterprise-grade. Data stays in M365 tenant. GDPR/SOC2 compliant.
Connectivity	Manual upload: PDFs, Docs, URLs, audio.	Upload per project. Claude 200MB / ChatGPT generous.	100+ live connectors: Slack, Jira, Salesforce & more.	Native: SharePoint, Teams, OneDrive, Outlook, Loop.
Audio Overviews	Industry-leading. Natural podcast-style.	Not available.	Not available.	Available in Copilot Notebooks. Newer, still maturing.
Best Fit for All For Less	Vendor docs, SOPs, policy — strict citable answers. Free.	Complex reasoning & strategy. Great complement.	Overkill — needs 100+ enterprise SaaS tools.	Poor fit — All For Less is on Google Workspace, not M365. Would mean a second ecosystem.

Verdict: All For Less runs on Google Workspace, so NotebookLM is the natural fit — documents already live in Google Drive.

NotebookLM vs. Copilot Notebooks — Why the Google Path Is Right for All For Less

FEATURE	Google NotebookLM (Enterprise)	Microsoft Copilot Notebooks (M365 Copilot — \$18-30/user/mo)
Cost	✓ Enterprise ~\$9/license/mo via Google Cloud.	\$30/user/mo (Enterprise) or \$18/user/mo (Business, <300 users). ⚠ Requires M365 license.
Data Privacy	ENTERPRISE ✓: DPA, no training use, VPC/IAM.	✓ Microsoft does NOT use M365 Copilot data to train foundation LLMs.
Fits Our Ecosystem	✓ NATIVE to Google Workspace. Our Docs, Sheets & Drive files are already here. No new platform.	⚠ Built for Microsoft 365. All For Less is a Google Workspace shop — would mean a second ecosystem.
Source Grounding	✓ Strict RAG — answers ONLY from your selected sources. Zero outside data.	✓ Notebook mode: grounded in referenced files. Can also access broader M365 knowledge.
Audio Overviews	✓ Industry-leading. Natural, conversational podcast-style. Supports many file types.	✓ Now available. Supports Word, PowerPoint, OneNote, PDF. Newer — still maturing vs. NotebookLM.
Citation Accuracy	✓ Per-sentence citations tied to exact source. Every claim is fully traceable.	⚠ Cites documents but may supplement with broader M365 knowledge. Less granular.
File Types	✓ Google Docs, Sheets, Slides, PDF, URLs. Enterprise adds DOCX, PPTX, XLSX.	DOCX, PPTX, XLSX, PDF, Loop, OneNote pages. First 20 reference files used for grounding.
Best Use at AFL	✓ The fit. Enterprise for vendor docs, SOPs, finance & buyer reports.	⚠ Strong tool, wrong ecosystem for us. Only makes sense if AFL migrated to Microsoft 365.

Verdict: All For Less runs on Google Workspace, so NotebookLM is the natural home — our documents already live in Google Drive. Start free, graduate to NotebookLM Enterprise for DPA-grade security. Copilot was considered but means a second ecosystem.

NotebookLM Strengths — Why It's the Right Starting Point

Technical Notes

- RAG-based architecture: answers grounded only in uploaded docs
- Gemini 3.5 — Google's current model generation (June 2026)
- Supports PDF, Google Docs, URLs, and plain text
- API-free deployment — no integration work required
- Audio Overview generation: summarizes docs in minutes

Business Notes

- Buyers instantly query vendor agreements & pricing sheets
- Store managers summarize corporate policy docs on demand
- Training content auto-converted to audio for warehouse staff
- Markdown & seasonal trend reports searchable in seconds

Key Insight: No servers. No integration work. No dev team required. Just upload a document and start asking questions.

Challenges, Drawbacks & Scalability

POTENTIAL DRAWBACKS

Fast-Moving Product

Google updates features, limits, and pricing often. Re-check terms before each phase.

No Real-Time Data

Only answers from uploaded documents. Will not pull live inventory or POS data without manual exports.

User Adoption

Some non-tech staff may need light training to trust and use AI-generated summaries effectively.

SCALABILITY PATH

Phase 1 • Now

Pilot with 5–10 buyers uploading vendor deal sheets. Measure time saved per week.

Phase 2 • 3 Months

Expand to store managers for SOP lookups. Create shared notebooks per region.

Phase 3 • 6 Months

Allow access to other user groups in the corporate office, such as Finance.

Ethics, Bias & Stakeholder Feedback Strategy

Ethical & Bias Considerations

Data Privacy

Vendor contracts and pricing data are confidential. Never upload PII or supplier terms.

AI Bias Risk

If source documents contain biased language, NotebookLM will reflect it. Human review of all AI outputs is essential.

Transparency

Communicate clearly with staff: AI is summarizing, not deciding. Cite source documents in all decisions.

Feedback & Engagement Strategy

Week 1-2: Pulse Survey

5-question survey to pilot users: time saved, confidence in AI outputs, adoption barriers.

Month 1: Exec Debrief

Present ROI metrics: cost avoidance, hours saved, fewer document-search requests.

Ongoing: Quarterly Review

IT and business leads review data incidents, governance, and readiness to scale.

Refine Continuously

Better organized source documents = better AI answers. Improve notebooks from survey feedback.

The Bottom Line

All For Less runs on Google Workspace. That makes the answer clear: NotebookLM is not just the right starting point — it is the right long-term home. Here is how we get there.

Start today

Pilot with 5-10 buyers. Zero IT setup. Measure the time saved in week one.

Easy to Add More Users

NotebookLM Enterprise (\$9/license/mo, 15-license min.) adds DPA, no-training guarantee, VPC/IAM security. Native to Google Drive.

Stay in one ecosystem

Our docs live in Google Workspace. NotebookLM Enterprise queries them natively — no manual uploads, no second platform.

Thank you • Questions?

